

Opening bids of 1 in a suit. The responses

Responder looks for a fit and measures strength: each response tells opener to stop or go on.



1 Three kinds of response

Limit bids

They show a minimum and a maximum: opener may pass.

Invitational

They show a limit but ask opener for something extra.

Forcing

A new suit: opener may not pass.

With 5 or more points never pass: opener may hold up to 20, and 25 between you means game.

2 Raises

RESPONSE	POINTS	MEANING
1♦ – 2♦	5-9	limit: with a minimum opener, no game
1♥ – 3♥	10-11	invitational: game if opener has 14+
1♠ – 4♠	max 11	4+ card fit and a hand made for ruffing

Over 1♥/1♠ three-card support is enough; over 1♦ you need four. Raises are not forcing.

PARTNER OPENS 1♦

♠ Q53 ♥ A5 ♦ Q874 ♣ 7654
→ 2♦: 7 points and four diamonds.

3 Revaluing with a fit

With a 4+ card fit and an unbalanced hand, responder adds to the HCP: number of trumps minus cards in the shortest suit.

PARTNER OPENS 1♥

♠ 8 ♥ KJ72 ♦ KQ74 ♣ 7642
9 HCP + (4 – 1) = 12 → 4♥.

Not with 4-3-3-3: without a short suit there is nothing to ruff.

4 New suits: forcing

RESPONSE	POINTS	MEANING
1♣ – 1♥	5+	one-over-one: 4+ cards, no upper limit; opener must bid again
1♠ – 2♦	12+	two-over-one: forcing to game

Opening 1♥ or 1♠ shows five; as a response, four are enough.

PARTNER OPENS 1♣

♠ 82 ♥ KJ72 ♦ Q92 ♣ 7642
→ 1♥: shows four hearts. Partner raises, bids 1♠ or rebids.

- Two five-card suits: the higher-ranking first.
- A five-card and a four-card suit: the five-card suit first.
- Two four-card suits: the cheaper first.

Don't jump if you can bid your suit at the 1 level: 1♥ shows 5 or more points, even 17.

5 Notrump responses

RESPONSE	POINTS	MEANING
1NT	5-10	not forcing; denies a 4-card suit biddable at the 1 level
2NT	11	invitational; denies a major-suit fit
3NT	12-15	game: balanced, no playable major

PARTNER OPENS 1♥

♠ 32 ♥ 4 ♦ QJ973 ♣ KQ852
Two five-card suits, only 8 points: too weak for the 2 level → 1NT.

6 Before you respond: a checklist

1 · Do I have a fit?

Show it now, at the level my points allow.

2 · If not, a new suit?

Bid it: it is forcing and has no upper limit.

3 · Neither?

Respond in notrump, according to my points.